

Nielsen Norman Group **Heuristic Evaluation Workbook**

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

EVALUATOR:

DATE: 05-17-2026

PRODUCT: Student Study Planner and
Deadline Tracker

TASK: Evaluation

1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

When a user checks off a subject task, (eg. finishing an assignment in Mathematics), the change doesn't instantly animate or show a clear "Success" confirmation toast, leaving the user unsure if the system registered the completion.

*Recommendations: Implement an immediate snackbar notification or micro-interaction (like the progress bar smoothly filling up with our sage green color) right after an action is completed to give instant visual feedback.

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2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

In the task creation menu, some fields use HTML like Task_ID_Foreign_Key or Timestamp_Interval instead of simple student language.

Recommendations

Revise all UI copy to match standard student terminology. Replace technical database phrases with user-friendly terms like "Subject Name," "Due Date," and "Reminder Time."

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

3

User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is *Undo* and *Redo* supported?

Issues

If a student accidentally deletes a deadline or logs the wrong study hours on the bar chart, there is no quick "Undo" button available. They have to re-enter the entire task manually.

Recommendations

Add an "Undo" floating option immediately after destructive actions (like deleting or modifying data) to allow users an easy "emergency exit" from accidental clicks.

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

The navigation placement is slightly inconsistent. On the main "Progress Tracker" screen, the navigation bars use rounded corner shapes, but on the "Tasks" submission layout, the buttons change to sharp, square edges.

Recommendations

Standardize the component properties across the entire Figma design system. Apply a uniform corner radius (e.g., 12px) to all interactive buttons and containers to keep the design language consistent.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

5

Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

The system allows students to set due dates in the past (e.g., accidentally setting a deadline for yesterday), which causes immediate system confusion and negative metrics on the tracker.

Recommendations

Constraint the input fields by graying out and disabling past calendar dates in the date picker panel, preventing the mistake before the form is submitted.

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

When looking at the "Weekly Study Hours" bar chart, users have to tap back into individual subject menus to remember what specific assignments they spent those hours working on.

Recommendations

Introduce a tool-tip or a small overlay menu that appears when a user hovers over or taps a specific day's bar, revealing a breakdown of the subjects studied that day without making them exit the screen.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

7

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

Regular users have to go through the complete multi-step form sequence ("Create" -> "Select Subject" -> "Set Time") every single time they want to log a quick study session.

Recommendations

Implement a "Quick Log" macro button or a swipe-to-start-timer gesture directly on the dashboard home screen for experienced users to record frequent habits instantly.

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

The subject list container is crowded with unnecessary metadata (such as professor names, room assignments, and course codes) which distracts from the core metrics like completion rate and pending counts.

Recommendations

Strip away the extra structural academic data from the tracker view. Hide non-essential information under an optional "View Course Details" dropdown to keep the screen clean and focused on task tracking.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

9

Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

When an invalid entry occurs during deadline setup, the system displays a generic alert message like "Error Code: Form Validation failed (400)" without clearly stating what went wrong.

Recommendations

When an invalid entry occurs during deadline setup, the system displays a generic alert message like "Error Code: Form Validation failed (400)" without clearly stating what went wrong.

10

Help and Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

When an invalid entry occurs during deadline setup, the system displays a generic alert message like "Error Code: Form Validation failed (400)" without clearly stating what went wrong.

Recommendations

Place small informational contextual icons (info tooltips) right next to section headers like "Completion Rate" and "Weekly Hours" so students can view quick definitions instantly without switching screens.